

Does AI search replace Google for a local business?

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PRIVATE REVIEW EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

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Source: 03-does-ai-search-replace-google-local-business.md

Typography: Archivo Black display, Georgia reading text and Calibri utility text. Georgia is a print-specific reading choice; the existing Momentum web design system is unchanged.

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Does AI search replace Google for a local business?

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

No. Not for a local service business, not this year. AI answers sit on top of Google and pull from the same sources: your Google Business Profile, your reviews, your service pages. What changes is the click. More people get an answer without visiting your site. What doesn't change is the phone, and the phone is where the job is.

I'll show you the numbers behind that, then what to do about it.

What do the search numbers actually say?

Two things at once, and both are true.

First, the interest is real. "AI overviews" gets about 110,000 searches per month in the US. It went from 33,100 a month in August 2025 to 201,000 in April 2026, then settled at 110,000 by July. "Google AI overviews" adds another 22,200 a month. "AI search" holds steady around 22,200. "Google search AI mode" is 18,100.

Second, a slice of people want it gone. "Hide Google AI overviews Chrome extension" gets about 5,400 searches per month in the US. That's thousands of people a month actively looking for a way to switch the feature off.

Put those together and you don't get a replacement. You get a feature that a lot of people are living with and some people are annoyed by. That's a change in how results look, not a change in who owns the search box.

Who is answering this question today?

Search "does AI search replace Google" and the first result is a Reddit thread. Then a TIME article from May 2026. Then an SEO firm's post titled, roughly, "the answer is no". Then a marketer's LinkedIn research, then Medium, Quora and MIT Technology Review. An AI Overview sits on top of all of it.

Every one of those is written about the whole internet. None of them is written for a plumber in Delaware County who wants to know if the phone is going to stop ringing. That's the version I'm writing.

What changes for a local service business?

Four things.

1. **The click gets rarer on informational questions.** If someone asks "how often should a furnace be serviced", the answer appears on the page. They may never visit anyone's site. That traffic was never your best traffic anyway.
2. **Citations replace positions.** An AI answer names two or three sources. You're in the sentence or you're not. There's no page two.

3. **Specific beats broad.** Homepages don't get cited. Procedures do. Our own site earned 81 citations in a sampled year of Google AI Overview answers, and the pages that got cited were a how-to on verifying a Google Business Profile, our Google Ads page and a DIY web design page. Each answers one question completely.
4. **The question gets longer.** People type sentences now. "Who installs heat pumps near Media PA and does financing." Your page has to answer a sentence, not match a keyword.

What doesn't change?

- **Your Google Business Profile is still the record.** AI Overviews are Google. They read what Google has.
- **Reviews are still the trust.** An engine that has to pick three businesses to name is going to lean on what customers said.
- **Google is still where the AI reads from.** If your site can't be crawled, no engine can cite it.
- **The phone is still the job.** Here's our own number, since I'm asking you to look at yours. On the agency's tracked line in July 2026, through the 27th, we had 263 inbound calls. 101 were answered. 162 were missed. That's a 38.4% answer rate. No AI engine changes that number. Only answering the phone does.

If you're worried about AI search and your answer rate looks like ours did, fix the phone first. It's cheaper and it's certain.

What should I do this month?

Three moves. None of them cost money.

1. **Run a baseline.** Write 20 questions your buyers ask before they call. Ask each one in Google with AI Overviews on and in ChatGPT. Log the engine, the exact prompt, the date and every source cited. Count how often you appear.
2. **Fix one page.** Pick your top service. Give it question-form headings, a direct answer under each, your service area, an author and a date. One page, done properly, beats ten pages touched lightly.
3. **Log the phone.** Every inbound call gets a source and an owner. If you can't say which calls came from where, no attribution report, AI or otherwise, will ever be true.

Then re-run the baseline in 30 days. Measure, fix one thing, re-measure. That's the whole method.

FAQ

Will AI Overviews take my traffic? Some clicks on informational questions will go away. Calls for a job still route to a business with a phone number and a clear service page. Measure your own numbers before you assume either way.

Should I stop doing SEO? No. The AI reads what search engines index. A site that can't be crawled gets cited nowhere. Good SEO is the floor AEO stands on.

Is ChatGPT a bigger deal than Google AI Overviews for a local business? I can only measure Google's AI Overviews with the tools I have. Test both with the same 20 questions and let your own log answer that for your trade.

The next step

If you want a second opinion on where you stand, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations about your business with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com with your top service and your city.